

Unlikely Angel

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The buck grimaced as he sprawled on his bed, cloven hooves kicked over the edge of the rumpled sheets. The only clothing he wore was a pair of red boxer shorts, seeing no need as he was in perfect solitude with the campus being closed. He had chosen a blue duvet cover, when the time had come to buy a duvet cover like any other student in his first semester of college, yet he would have preferred green. The blue duvet cover had been heavily discounted, however, so he had had no choice in the matter: finances dictated much of what he did.

Casting his eyes across the room, he scowled at the scholarship paperwork on the desk, piled neatly enough but still a sore spot. It should have been a source of pride that a buck from Cody's background had been able to scrape together enough of them to study Advanced Physics, or whatever they called the course these days, as they seemed to refer to it by a different name every other week or so. In sleepless New York, Binghamton had accepted him as a student, though the winter snows sent chills through his coat of short, brown fur. Cody grumbled. He did not grow a thick enough winter coat to ward off the cold, especially when the heating was turned down to zero.

A second single bed resided a couple of metres away, allowing the individual roommates some sleeping privacy, with the sheets made up pristinely. He snorted and shook his head, being of an untidier breed himself. He had little to actually make a mess of. His roommate was a strange one indeed. The Black Panther groomed his surroundings until they gleamed but forgot to maintain his own appearance, leaving whiskers kicked and fur sticking up in all directions. At least he did not forget to shower.

The buck muttered under his breath as he kicked himself to his hooves, rocking his body upright in a lithe spring of motion. His fingertips danced along his forearm as he halted halfway through the motion of striding across the room, leg outstretched, as if all the energy had suddenly left his body. Paw falling to his side, the buck frowned. What was he doing, getting up, anyway? What exactly did he think he was going to do? He'd had enough walks around campus to last him a lifetime and, with everyone home on Christmas Eve, there was not even anything interesting to see.

Listlessly, he pawed at his chest of drawers, tucking a stray shirt back amongst its fellows. There was no point in anything else, nothing to do and nowhere to be. Cody sighed. There was no one to be nowhere with either.

The fuck am I meant to do? Cody thought, scuffing a hoof over the carpet where a line was worn through the fibre. *Every day, it's just the same. Sure, study is great and all that, I know I'm lucky, but where's the rest of it? Everyone else seems to be having fun, why not me? I got here, didn't I? Don't I deserve some fun too?*

His ears drooped.

A friend?

Money was the currency of college and, while even the most strained of students could usually afford to sit in their dorm with filched drinks, Cody did not have the simplest of

luxuries. Dorm and student fees sapped so much of his money that he was lucky if he had enough left every semester to feed himself. And even then he pilfered from free buffets at the college and discount food from the supermarkets, wherever he could traipse at closing time to find the cheapest sustenance. Hell, once he'd even begged at a food drive where they gave out hot meals to the needy. That had been his only hot meal that week.

Frowning, the buck lifted the shirt he had been toying with to his muzzle and took a sniff. His eyes widened and his arms shot away from his body, holding the shirt at arm's length as his muzzle contorted. It could not have been that long since he had done a load! The buck grumbled, crumpled the shirt into a ball and tossed it on a floor, checking the stash of coins on his chest of drawers. He had a few quarters left, only a few.

Groaning, Cody tossed the clothes into a free carrier bag, filling it and then a second to the point where the plastic threatened to burst. He may be alone on Christmas Eve but life would go on regardless. The buck fingered his antlers. He almost wished his life would not go on. But he could not think like that.

The laundry would not do itself.

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Cody shivered and hunched his shoulders against the bite of wind. Not for the first time that winter, the buck wished desperately that he had a scarf, something to keep winter's cold fingers from his throat at the very least. Once, when he was younger, one of his foster families had given him a fantastic scarf in red and yellow stripes: the colours of Gryffindor. A huge Harry Potter fan, it had been the gift of the year and he had worn it everywhere, even when the summer months encroached. Eventually though, he moved on from that foster family like he had all the others before and, somewhere along the way, the scarf became lost forever. Not unlike him.

He shuddered and ducked his head as the wind picked up flurries of snow and he trod along the barely visible path bare-hoofed. There were no other tracks ahead and no lights glowing from dorms or campus buildings as cloud cover darkened the night sky. It could not have been that late, perhaps seven or eight in the evening, but it could have been the dead of night for all the life the campus cradled.

Cody laughed, the sound harsh and echoing in the frozen air. Snow crunched beneath his hooves.

"'Twas the night before Christmas, when all through the house," he muttered, "not a creature was stirring...except one stupid buck."

Tightening his grip on the laundry bags, Cody kept his head down against falling snow and made his way slowly but steadily towards the laundrette on campus. Most students scorned the little laundry room for its near enough broken down machines but Cody found it did the job all right, even if he had to give the dryer a kick every now and again.

Blowing into his paws, the buck squinted through the chill breeze and looked back at his hoof prints as he approached the utilities building. Part of another dorm, the rectangular black door for the laundrette was difficult to spot in the gloom. As the campus had been deserted, the

lights had been switched off where paths would have previously been illuminated, leaving him to find his way purely by his senses.

At last, he padded up to the door and pushed experimentally on the right side, expecting it to swing open at his touch – it had never been locked before. When it did not immediately move away from his hoofed fingertips, the buck started and tilted his antlers speculatively. Trying the handle gave him no different results and Cody stared at it, lips parted in comic shock. The carrier bags weighed heavily in his paws, plastic cutting lines of pain into his palms.

“Closed?” He blinked at the door, raising his voice until it cracked in his throat. “*Closed?* You have got to be kidding me.”

Anger flared, racing through his veins like wildfire. It wasn’t fair! All he wanted to do was his damn laundry! Was that too much to ask?

Cody stomped childishly and flung the bags at the door, where they hit and exploded in a shower of dirty clothes.

“No one even mans this!” He shouted at the closed door as if it would answer him. “They could have left it open for us! Whoever was left on campus! But nooooo, of course not, that would be too fricking easy!”

Unwelcome tears pricked the corners of the buck’s eyes and he swept them away with his knuckles, pressing them into the sockets until lights flashed across his vision. It was ridiculous to be tearful over a locked laundry room but in the moment it felt like the world was crashing down around his ears. Only one thing needed to go right, just one. That was not too much to ask. Or was it?

He stared at the carrier bags, clothes dampening as flakes of snow melted on their surface, though they were only slightly warmer than the outside air. He heaved a sigh that had the weight of his young years behind it and gathered up the strewn fabrics, shoving them back into the bags with a rough, quick paw. When able, he would try the laundrette outside campus, if he could afford it. Shivering, the buck resolved to warm himself, now that he had ventured into the great cold. There was no sense in wasting a walk and there was always one place on campus that was open, if but for a time.

The buck trudged through the snow with his paws dug into his pockets, arms through the handles of the bags so that they hung at the inside crease of his elbow. Cody thought of his parents. The deer held no memories of them, bar ones that he had concocted for himself – a light, musical laugh that soothed him to rest as a fawn and a warm, steady paw guiding him. His heart twisted and he clamped down on emotion, locking it deep inside where he did not have to acknowledge it existed. Though they were long gone, he knew his parents would not have wanted him to be cold. Cody gritted his teeth. The buck had to keep his head high and all would come right in the end.

Or so he had to believe.

Approaching the student club, he was unsurprised to find it in darkness, as there would be no business for the university while most of its clientele was away celebrating. He snorted, wishing it was open, though wishing had never gotten him anywhere. The modern exterior of

the club was silent and forlorn, a far cry from the pulsing music and strobe lights that he was more used to. He had never been to the club to ‘party’ but had worked there upon occasion on the doors for extra money. A stag could be quite intimidating dressed in black with the right level of padding beneath. He smiled at the memory, amusement tickling as he passed the club, back to the building.

Cody paused, ears twitching. In the alley to the far side of the club, something moved. He stopped in his tracks and peered down the alley, looking past a wheelie bin to where darkness flickered, the movement barely discernible and so faint that Cody could have mistaken it for his imagination.

“Hello?” Cody called out hesitantly.

No response was forthcoming, though the movement came again, a living being shifting in the half-light reflecting off the snow. The deer hesitated, shifting his weight anxiously from hoof to hoof. Ice seeped into his bones.

“Hello?” Cody coughed into his fist, narrowing his eyes as he peered down the alley, bins half-obstructing his vision. “Is anyone there?”

He paused. It was cold.

“Are you okay?”

He wanted to move on but he could not have lived with himself if he left some fur in the cold, hiding down an alley from who knew what. Though his fingers were frozen in his pockets, Cody crunched down the alleyway, back straight and ears turning to catch every minute sound. A sinuous brown shape leaned back against the wall, a flash of lighter fur under his rounded chin betraying him as an otter. Cody sighed in relief, as there seemed to be nothing wrong with the strange fur, bundled up in warm clothes as he was in the middle of a deserted campus.

Edging closing, the buck extended his paw, a few metres from the otter, who had his lips parted enough for the buck to see his sharp, fish-catching teeth.

“Are you okay?” He asked and then wished in the next instant that he had not ventured down the alleyway at all.

The otter was not alone. Moaning, he arched away from the wall, thrusting his hips out sensually. Stripes glared in the shadows and the otter rested his paw on the top of another fur’s head, which was at the same level as his crotch. Cody’s eyes widened.

The zebra knelt on the frozen ground, knees spread apart for balance. His stripes clashed starkly in the gloom of the alleyway but his heavy, grey coat did nothing to hide the cock straining his lips wide. Bobbing his muzzle slowly, the zebra paid no attention to the slack-jawed buck, paws splayed flat against his partner’s thighs. The otter locked his gaze with Cody’s, smirking at him as his hips moved faster and faster, dragging the equine’s muzzle down on his cock so that the pink shaft was enveloped by long, zebra muzzle.

He should have left right then and there, yet Cody was transfixed. His gaze roamed down to the cock plunging between the zebra's lips as the otter shuddered and thrust roughly, whole body jerking as he reached a quick climax. The zebra's throat worked as he swallowed, cum disappearing straight down his gullet as the otter groaned deep in his throat, a thick, guttural sound of male pleasure. Pinching the zebra's ear, he held him in close, muzzle grinding into his crotch fur until he was good and satisfied.

Cody gulped, standing still. It was far too late to run.

The zebra let the softening cock slip from of his lips with a wet pop, cum drawing out in a string between the tapered shaft and his startlingly pink tongue. Sitting back on his hooves, he raised an eyebrow and crooked his fingers in a 'come hither' motion towards Cody.

"Hey stud," he nickered, lip curling back from his teeth to taste the air. "Are you next?"

Heat flooded the buck's cheeks and he turned on his heel so that he did not have to look at the zebra's stupid smirk any more. Laughter chased his heels as he trotted from the alley, bags swinging noisily against his sides. What a fool he had been to assume that some fur had needed help! The buck cursed himself inwardly and smashed his hoof through a snow drift, sending chunks of ice flying where it had frozen in deeper.

Cody struggled with himself, waging a mental war against an invisible foe that hurled insult after insult at his cowering form. Why did they have to laugh at him like that? He had thought someone was hurt, for heaven's sake! He had tried to do a good thing and he had let himself down once again. It was always the same. The buck gnawed the inside of his cheek and drew his laundry bags in close to his chest, ignoring the crinkles as he hugged himself for comfort and warmth.

You are useless.

The buck closed his eyes.

No, I am not.

They'll be laughing at you for days. You'll be the butt of all their jokes.

I did nothing wrong.

Oh, but you did.

How?

By existing.

No!

He shook snow from his antlers and charged off the path to mounds of snow, layered beautifully over grass. Trees dotted the mounds, strategically landscaped, and the buck darted between them, hooves flying as he fled his demons. Cold air raked his lungs with icy claws

and his eyes bulged. Somewhere along his wild dash, he slipped, snow balling up beneath his hoof, and tumbled head first into a snow drift, a puff of powder erupting in his fall.

He coughed and blinked, floundering as he it threatened to swallow him. Panic rose in his throat and Cody half-yelped, a strangled noise that did not carry in the world of white around him. He kicked out and crawled from the drift, snow sticking to the fur on the back of his neck as if he had suddenly grown a stark white mane like a horse. Shocked from his flight, the buck shook his head and stumbled to his feet, calves trembling and trousers dampened with now melting snow. Cody spun in a slow circle, calming his breathing as he took in the desolate campus, snow dropping from deciduous tree branches whenever a branch took too much of a burden. He could relate.

Maybe he needed to drop some of his burden too.

Tossing the bags on the snow, the buck giggled, the wicked burble bubbling up unbidden from his throat. As if he was again a young fawn playing with his friends, he bounded into the air with a shriek, letting his own folly spur him on. He swung out his hoof, skimming it cover the surface of the snow so he sent clumps flying, breaking apart in midair. Cody barked a laugh and dove into it, destroying the pristine surfaces wherever his hoof touched. Hoof prints were no longer the currency of the day and he stomped through drifts, fingertips tingling with the sheer exhilaration with being truly and utterly alone to do as he willed. The buck leapt and twisted, sprawling back on the snow only to spring up with even greater energy than before, tail twitching. It no longer mattered what hand the world had dealt him was. He was Cody and he was free in the moment.

The buck staggered to a drunken halt, half-tipping over as laughter made his sides heave and he fought to stay upright. He leaned over, paws flat against his thighs, and wheezed, ears flipping back at the shard of pain spearing his lungs. It was too much exertion for a buck who could have afforded to go to the – admittedly free – campus gym a little more, heart hammering and blood pumping hotly. Cody certainly no longer felt the cold. The buck's laughs trickled off into chuckles that refused to die down, rumbling up from his belly like growls of hunger.

He may have looked ridiculous dancing through the snow, though the buck reckoned if he was mad in his mind, he may as well play the part.

“Having fun there, are you?”

Cody's head snapped up and his lips twisted into a scowl. The zebra from the alleyway leaned against a tree, arms crossed across his broad chest. His black and white mane rose from the back of his head and neck in a traditional zebra Mohawk and his lips curved up in an easy, lopsided smile. The buck shook his head and straightened, searching for his carrier bags amongst the white. How much had the buck seen? Was he there to make fun of him? He raised his chin defiantly, stifling the urge to swallow. Let him mock, if he dared. Cody's paw curled into a fist.

Besides, it was not him that had been caught sucking off another fur in an alley.

“Yeah, I was actually,” he retorted sharply. “What's it to you?”

“Nothing at all,” the zebra answered. “Though it is strange indeed to find another student here so far from Christmas cheer.”

Cody barked a laugh, breath frosting and the sound echoing mirthlessly.

“There’s little to be had of Christmas when you’re like me.”

Cody sighed and rolled his shoulders in a shrug as the zebra studied him.

“That’s very negative.”

“Welcome to my world.”

Cody growled, throat rumbling – a most unusual noise for an anthro deer to make. What was the zebra’s problem, sneaking up on him? Was he not allowed to have fun now too? Perhaps the zebra was simply after more ‘fun’ like what he had been having with the panther in the alley, another cock to suck and another fur to use. The buck’s eyes narrowed and he snatched up a carrier bag from the ground, reaching for the second as he spat out words. Anything to get the stupid equine to make good and leave.

“Shouldn’t you be with your *buddy*?”

Cody did not mean to sound as venomous as he did but he kept his gaze stern. He’d be bugged if he would let the zebra take advantage of him. The buck was better than that.

Snorting, the zebra shook his head, brushing a paw devoid of glove through his short mane. Cody watched his blue eyes as they slipped away from his, shocking in their clarity and most unnatural for a zebra. Holding his paws up to either side as if to make a ‘what can you do?’ motion, the zebra dropped a conspirator’s wink to the buck.

“Never seen him before, never gonna see him again.” The zebra grinned. “Such is life and such are my travels. Name’s Nick. What do they call you?”

“Ass, mostly.”

Cody did not think before speaking and inwardly cringed, grabbing the second bag from the ground to loop both over his arms. The plastic crinkled obnoxiously in the background as Nick gave a great, big belly laugh that rumbled up from his gut.

“Whereas I am confident your arse is a charming feature, I daresay it’s getting quite cold now,” Nick countered, a true smile brightening his muzzle. “Freezing my bloody tail off here. You want to go somewhere?”

Cody took a step back.

“I’m not up for anything like what you were doing...back there,” Cody trailed off, unable to force out the exact words he wanted to say. “Trust me, dude, just because I’m hanging around campus on Christmas Eve doesn’t mean I’m desperate. Or that I swing that way,” he hastened to add. “Only trying to get by. As you do.”

The zebra waved a paw dismissively, turning his muzzle away with what Cody could have sworn was a blush.

“No...” He grumbled. “No one was meant to see that. To be fair, I didn’t think anyone would be wandering around at this time at Christmas.”

“So giving a blowjob in an alley was an option?”

Nick raised an eyebrow and grinned, bringing a finger to his lips to wickedly ‘shush’ the buck.

“It can be, upon occasion,” he said evasively, “with the right individual.”

Knowing in his gut that he was not about to obtain any sure answers anytime soon from the thus named Nick, Cody shrugged, half-turning towards his dorm and the beckoning light that he knew still flickered within in the adjoining hallway. It would be a side warmer than the outside and the buck shivered, hugging his arms around himself for a scrap of warmth.

Nick stepped closer, ears pricked to attention.

“Come on.” The zebra extended a paw, smile warming his blue eyes. “Let me buy you a drink. You can’t have been going anywhere other than *Stoat’s Den* at this hour, let alone on Christmas Eve.”

Cody sighed.

“I can’t drink, I’m eighteen. Worked too hard to get here to risk that now. You should know that, if you’re a student here too. Though I haven’t seen you around.”

“Who’s going to book you on Christmas Eve?” Nick cajoled, ears drooping in faux sadness. “You’d leave a poor zebra out in the cold with no one to have a drink with?”

Cody chuckled unwillingly at his antics. He was a character indeed, it had to be said.

“If a drink was all it was – and you were buying – then it wouldn’t matter, but I’m not getting past anyone with no ID and no wallet on me.”

Nick considered this, running a finger down the upper side of his long muzzle. Cody tried not to think of what that muzzle had been doing only a short time ago, putting his resulting shiver down to the cold and not the unwelcome warmth coursing through his abdomen.

Behave...

“I’ll get you in and buy you a drink,” the zebra said after a pause that seemed to have stretched out far longer than was necessary. “If it makes you feel any better, I’m twenty-one, so of the legal age in your country. I forget that it’s not eighteen over here sometimes.”

He hesitated, rubbing his forearm through the thick, grey coat.

“Sound okay?”

Digesting new information – the zebra had a strange accent but Cody would not have assumed he was not from the US at the very least – the buck nodded absently and then the zebra was already walking away. By the time he returned to his senses, he felt he had no choice but to follow and did so with a dipped muzzle, trotting to catch up and wondering what exactly he had gotten himself into.

They strode through campus in companionable silence, heading towards the outskirts where Cody knew the bar Nick had mentioned was not far. Alcohol was not served at the present time on this campus as it was too great a temptation for underage students, though venues outside were less scrupulous, or so he had heard. Cody had not drank alcohol for a long time and even the thought of having a friendly drink bought for him – though who knew what the zebra's true intentions were – warmed him.

"I wasn't going to the bar, you know," Cody said as he walked alongside the zebra. "I really don't have my wallet on me."

"Oh? Then what were you out at this time for?"

"Laundry." Cody chuckled. The notion of doing laundry and becoming so frustrated now seemed absurd. "Was all locked up though."

"Mm, that is not surprising, though I am sure it would have been useful, since you were meaning to go there."

The zebra tilted his head, expensive hoof-boots treading down hard packed snow.

"You never told me what your name was, you know."

"It's Cody," the buck admitted as if parting with a great secret.

"That wasn't so hard now, was it?" Nick grinned and bumped his shoulder, juddering the buck off balance. "Not going to get into your national insurance or anything, don't worry."

"National insurance?" Cody's brow furrowed. "What's that?"

"Ah, I'm sorry – I forget the terms sometimes," Nick slid his gaze away thoughtfully. "I think it's similar to your social security, though I can't be sure. I'd have to look it up."

"You're definitely not from here then?" Cody prodded tentatively.

"Nope! British." The zebra chuffed. "You didn't get the accent?"

"I'm not too good with accents," the buck chuckled shyly, a blush warming his cheeks. "Hope I didn't offend."

"Not at all."

Following the zebra's lead, Cody allowed himself to be led further and further from his dorm, eventually leaving the bounds of campus. *Stoat's Den* was down a side street, ideally placed

for sly students, with an illuminated, tacky neon sign outside depicting the name. The neon pink dots surrounding the yellow place name had burned out, all but one, leaving it appearing forgotten amongst the silently falling snow. The flakes were smaller now and Nick stepped ahead of Cody to hold the door open, muzzle bowed gracefully as the buck stepped past him into the warmth within. Resting his paw on the buck's arm, Nick guided him with the lightest of touches through the near empty bar, strewn with beaten up tables and chairs and a stoat – as the name implied – behind the bar with a distrustful look in his eye. Heart pounding harder than was strictly comfortable, Cody nodded his thanks, eyes carefully averted.

Collapsing into a secluded booth, Nick shrugged out of his coat and tossed it over the back, watching as Cody slid into the place opposite him. At the back end of the bar, it was quiet enough that they could not discern what the few other patrons were saying, which put Cody at greater ease. The zebra winked.

“What’s your poison then?”

Cody scratched his neck.

“I wouldn’t know, I don’t drink all that much. Rarely. I’ll have what you’re having,” Cody fumbled with his words, hoping that it was the right thing to say.

“Sure thing.”

Sliding easily out of his seat, Nick padded to the bar, hooves oddly muted by the boots. Cody leaned out of the booth to get a better look at them, briefly envious of the money behind those. He crossed his cold ankles over one another underneath the round table, rubbing his forearms to warm up as the zebra smoothly collected two pints of beer from the stoat at the bar and returned to the booth.

“Did you miss me?”

Cody raised an eyebrow but otherwise made no comment, leaning back in the booth. He reached for the drink and took an experimental sip, the ‘wheaty’ taste on his tongue familiar from earlier years when he had been all too keen to down a bottle. He cringed at the memory and took a heftier gulp.

“Thanks for the drink,” he said awkwardly, lifting his paw up from the table as if to make a gesture of thanks that he did not quite know how to make. “It’s...nice of you.”

“No problem,” Nick said, taking a draught of his beer so that a froth of white coated his upper lip. “What actually brings you out on a night like this? I can hardly believe that you traipsed through the snow purely for clean clothes. It’s hardly a student requirement.”

Cody hesitated. What was he doing, talking to a stranger? He could not speak so frankly. To occupy himself while he bought time, he drank deeply of the beer, the level of liquid in the glass disappearing more swiftly than was strictly sensible.

“What did you mean when you said you wouldn’t see that panther again?” Cody dodged the initial question, pouncing instead of a far more tempting topic that had been niggling at the corner of his mind. “Are you a one night stand kind of guy?”

“Why, you interested?”

“Hardly,” Cody snorted, though the sly gleam in his eye betrayed his cunning mirth. “I prefer guys with a little more muscle than you.”

“Muscle?” The zebra’s nostrils flared. “Are you saying I’m *skinny*? I’ll show you muscle!”

Before Cody could correct his ill-timed joke, Nick yanked his t-shirt, emblazoned with a band that Cody did not recognise, up over his head and dropped it on the table, muscles flexing. Light glanced off a gleaming striped coat, black and white patterning elegantly over bulging muscle and a delicious six-pack. Cody stared slack-jawed at the zebra, who he could only describe as ripped, as the proud equine ostentatiously flexed, paws curled into fists so that the hoofed tips, similar to Cody’s dug lightly into his palms. Ducking his muzzle provocatively to the side, the zebra smiled so seductively that Cody’s breath caught in his throat.

A coarse shout interrupted his stare.

“Hey!” The stoat leaned over the bar with a dish cloth in one paw and his lips twisted distastefully. “Clothes *on* in the bar!”

Nick jumped and lunged for his shirt, unable to keep the grin from his lips as he pulled the red fabric over his head, ears popping out, and shoved his arms through the sleeves. Cody shrank back into the booth, torn between laughter and pretending that he no longer existed, that he was not there and subject to the embarrassment of being shouted at in a *bar*.

“Sorry!” Nick whinnied, amusement colouring his tone.

The stoat retreated, muttering about ‘kids these days’, as Cody and Nick collapsed into stifled giggles, leaning in closer to one another like two schoolboys. When laughter retreated, Cody grasped his glass and drained the dregs, wishing he had another. The warmth of alcohol and laughter stirring his body was a treat he had forgotten and he shot a look at the zebra, who nonchalantly drank, his glass still reasonably full.

“What is it about you?” Cody blurted out, shaking his head so that his antlers scraped across the back of the booth. “Why are you...like this?”

Tilting his head to one side, Nick’s ears pricked up, the petals swivelling to attention.

“Are you asking me why I am as I am?”

In the zebra’s mouth, the words seemed silly, childish, and Cody splayed his paw flat on the table, lips twisting as he considered the notion.

“Well, let me give you an example,” he tried instead. “Forgive my crassness but you were in an alleyway sucking off a panther not so long ago and now you’re in here with me.” He swallowed. “What are you trying to do?”

The zebra sat up, paws resting in his lap, hidden by the curve of the table.

“You think I’m trying to get you in bed.”

“Something along those lines.”

In stark contrast to their mirth, uncomfortable silence enveloped their private booth, the very atmosphere of the bar becoming darker. With the alcohol buzzing through his body on an empty stomach – quick to act – Cody swore that the lights dimmed, if only marginally. Shifting his weight, he tapped the tips of his fingers together, too wound up to sit still for more than a couple of seconds at a time. Nick leaned back with his paws behind his head, looking up at the ceiling. In the quiet, his nostrils flared.

It was unbearable. Cody’s heart thudded quicker and quicker, painful against his ribcage, and his breath rasped. Leaning forward as the zebra sat slightly to the side of the booth, he narrowed the distance between them, something in him disliking how Nick moved away.

“Did you follow me?”

Nick hesitated and rubbed the back of his neck, fingers grazing the zebra Mohawk of hair.

“Is it creepy to say that, yes, I did?”

Cody frowned.

“A little. Why?”

He huffed and blew warm air up, nostrils flaring again. Cody wondered if it was a sign of lying or simply a note that he was nervous. It was impossible to tell with a fur that was still near enough a stranger to him.

“The way you shot out of the alleyway...” Nick stroked his chin, the light bristle of hair there. “Now, I don’t play around much but usually it’s pretty funny to be caught, if it does happen, stupid students and all that entails. But you didn’t have the same look as the others. I can’t explain it.”

He nipped his lower lip and rested his elbows on the table, eyes downcast as if all the life had been sucked out of his body. Nick’s earlier joviality was long gone and his muscles trembled lightly from tension as his tail thwapped the table legs, a low, repetitive beat. With the beer further warming his system, Cody found it difficult to remain on edge around the zebra, ears flicking to catch his words. He knew on a deeper level that the conversation was more serious than his befuddled mind made it out to be, yet could not find it in himself to engage caution that had once prevailed. He really should not drink on an empty stomach.

“I guess...” Nick spoke slowly, tasting his words before allowing them out. “I saw something of me in you, as cheesy as that sounds.”

As if embarrassed, the zebra folded his arms across his wide chest, muscles bulging as he slanting his gaze away, a light pink tint colouring his cheeks just below his eyes. The buck struggled to take in what he had been told, caught between thoughts that demanded attention and precedence in the moment, too many to keep track of or understand as they flitted by. He could not imagine anyone having as bad a time of it as him. If so...what could have

happened? Cody watched intently as he blinked and threw any remaining shreds of caution to the wind, reaching out to brush the back of Nick's paw with his own, if but for a fraction of a heartbeat. The zebra jumped at the contact and stared wide-eyed, muscles shivering beneath the skin in an equine reflex that no other mammal seemed able to master.

"That is cheesy but in a nice way," he said, his tone soft. "If you really do see yourself in me, I hope it is lesser rather than greater." Alcohol loosened his tongue. "I would not wish my life upon my greatest enemy."

Studying the grain of the table, Nick reached out to take Cody's paw warmly in his own, hoofed digits trembling. The buck sat very still, fearful that if he moved even a muscle, he would scare off his new...friend, if he could be called that yet.

"I would say the same, sometimes people don't realise what hard times others are going through, though that also sounds corny." The zebra grimaced. "I'm not doing a very good job of this, am I?"

He laughed, colour returning to his tone.

"Either way, I thought I should follow you. And here we are." He raised an eyebrow, lips quirking in a smile. "However...perhaps we should not have met while I was indulging my passions behind the club."

Cody blinked, clapping a paw over his lips to stifle up the traitorous giggle threatening to break free.

"It was silly to think that you followed me to sleep with me," the buck played his glass between his paws, scooting it over the table top. "I did not mean to overreact... I'm sure you get why I did."

"It was perhaps not so daft to assume," Nick chuckled. "I would never force anyone. It's hard to believe after you've walked in on me like that, but I am selective with my partners. There has to be something special there, a connection. Otherwise it's no fun at all."

His gaze locked with Cody's and the buck pulled his head back, startled by the driving force, the intensity, behind them. He broke the meeting with some difficulty and cleared his throat, brushing his paw across his exposed collar bones.

"Just as well you didn't want to get with me."

Cody chuckled sheepishly, thrown off guard. He reached for his glass and then withdrew his paw, realising in the next instant that it was empty. "I've never been with anyone, let alone a guy. If you get around, I'm sure you head for the more experienced type. Not a damn virgin like me."

He licked his lips, clumsier than he would have been normally. Drumming a tune across the table top, Cody hummed to himself, little tail twitching where it could not be seen. His arm nudged the carrier bags of clothes, still waiting to be washed, though he could not find it in himself to care. Let them be unwashed. The laundrette would open again soon and he would

use his last quarters to sort himself out for another couple of weeks, fresh and clean and raring to go. Maybe he would save the dimes for another beer...

He looked up to see Nick studying him with a shy glimmer in his eye.

“Actually, I think you’re pretty cute.”

The buck started, jerking upright from where he had slowly slumped forward over the table, limbs looser than he would have liked.

“What?”

The zebra held up his paws.

“What do you want me to say? You *are* cute,” he elaborated, smile widening as he gulped hard. “I thought that would be a compliment.”

“It is...” Cody stumbled over his words, tongue-tied. “But why would I be of any interest to you?”

“Heh...” Nick clasped his paws on top of his longer muzzle, pulling it down to his chest in an overly coy motion that made Cody’s heart leap wickedly. “Not just anyone gets me out of my shirt, you know. Like what I was trying to say – and badly too – I can’t explain it. Can anyone? There’s something about you, Cody. There’s a glow to you.”

Tugging at the collar of his shirt, the zebra suddenly scooted across the booth so that his hip pressed to Cody’s and, with surprising delicacy, he snaked an arm around the buck’s waist. His paw, which had never left Cody’s, tightened in a squeeze. Like the typical deer in the headlights, the buck froze, eyes wide and half-glazed over. His mind worked overtime and he shivered, closing his eyes against the onslaught of thoughts, heart pounding and nerves tingling. How was he supposed to act?

“You’re alone tonight, aren’t you, Cody?”

The buck nodded, not trusting himself to speak. He did not know what he wanted – how could he possibly know what he wanted? All through his life, decisions had been thrust upon him, even the education he had battled for personally. It had been the only option for him, the only option that allowed him to keep living, for all the good that did him. When had he ever had a choice to make himself? Everything was clear and sensible and normal otherwise! He focused on school and making something of himself, not other furs. Chest tightening, Cody took back his paw, placing each paw on his opposite bicep for a comforting squeeze, half a hug. Every past injustice snarled from the shadows, stalking him with gleaming, red eyes. Demons were his everyday and the buck had no notion of the sweeter side.

And now a zebra with kind eyes and a warm paw sat before him, inviting him closer with words yet unspoken. Cody trembled.

“If you want...” He hesitated, conflict battling in his eyes. “Only if you want...I could come back to your dorm with you. To talk, to keep you company...or something more.”

He held up one finger, throat working as he swallowed.

“Only if you want it. I must warn you though that, as I said, I will be leaving tomorrow, early on. I don’t want to disappoint you, buck.”

He squeezed around Cody’s waist, chin resting lightly on top of his head. Unconsciously, the buck leaned into the zebra, tilting his muzzle away so that his antlers would not give Nick an untimely clout. There would be no easier way to sour the mood. Decisions still would not come, even after buying himself time. Nausea washed over him and Cody steeled himself, curling his free paw into a tight fist. One decision remained untouched. He did not have to do anything. Nothing at all. He could just have company, if that was all he wanted. And his heart had been too lonely for too long.

To hell with it...

“I’ll...” Words felt thick in his mouth and Cody had to clear his throat several times before speech was feasible. “You can come back with me. I don’t make any promises either. These years have been nothing but failures and promises I couldn’t keep.”

He grimaced. *Cheesy*. Nick did not mind and slipped out of the booth with an awkward hop, extending his paw to help Cody up.

“Then let us bid the bar adieu, buck, and make tracks to the place you call home, for now.” He rubbed his thumb over the back of Cody’s paw. “Maybe some games or a film to watch would serve us well tonight.”

Cody’s heart pounded as he took the lead out of the bar, cloven hooves clumsy in his haste to leave. He did not know what he was doing. His palms were sweaty and he could not make eye contact with the stoat behind the bar. Snow blasted into his face and he lifted his paw to shield his muzzle from it, squinting to see through. The winds had picked up and it would be a trek and a half to reach his dorm, though he did not have the heart to kindly release his company now that the zebra was so willingly trotting behind, crunching through the snow.

He raced across campus without saying a word, the wind sending tears down his cheeks that froze to his short fur. Was the weather trying to work against him? Stubbornly, he hurled his body against the wind, grinding his way through step by step as his curved nostrils flared.

“Hey...easy,” Nick murmured, trotting to catch up with the buck. “You don’t have to run like the hounds of hell are at your hooves. I’m here. Trying to keep up with you.”

The buck glanced back at the snow speckled zebra.

“Maybe I’m just keen to get back,” Cody said, almost too low to be heard over the rising howl of wind.

Tilting his head, the zebra smiled gently and rested a paw in the curve of Cody’s waist.

“I can keep you warm, sweet buck.”

Cody's cheeks heated up and he ducked his muzzle shyly, though made no move to remove the paw, drawing Nick along with his quick pace.

"I can only hope you will."

The dorm loomed ahead and, with the buzz of beer warming his mind if not this body, the buck towed. The door closed behind and Cody turned sharply, bumping straight into a jacket that smelled softly of cologne, stretched over a muscled chest he hoped to become more familiar with.

Whinnying, the zebra dipped his muzzle a few inches to butt cutely against Cody's, lips a hair's breadth away. In hindsight, Cody would have blamed it on the alcohol but

"Oh, my sweet buck..." Nick nickered, paw curling possessively around Cody's cheek. "The things I could teach you...but only if you want me to."

He paused, eyes innocently hopeful.

"Would you like that...Cody?"

"Please..." The buck breathed, the lack of words saying more than his lips ever could have.

They stumbled up the stairs in each other's arms, Nick shielding Cody from all the unwanted bumps and scraps that he could. Crashing through Cody's dorm door, the zebra kicked the door shut, paws on either side of the buck's muzzle to kiss him deeply, lips parted for tongues to meet intimately.

In the half-light of the scattered lamps glancing off the snow outside, they undressed one another, Nick struggling out of hoof-boots with a giggle that did not suit him. Before they knew it, the males were nude on the bed and Cody was moaning as Nick kissed down his neck to his chest, lips teasing a path over his pectorals.

"Easy..."

"Come here, buck," the zebra murmured, lips tickling Cody's ear. "Lay back and let me take good care of you, make you feel good."

Hesitating, Cody shivered and turned his muzzle into Nick's neck, hiding as his tapered rod of stag-flesh nuzzled into the zebra's abdomen, shy in appearance. Less subtly, the thick, black cock boasted by the zebra slapped his thigh as he moved, paws gentle as they guided Cody's down and invited him to enjoy as he would.

"I'm not sure..." Cody blushed, paw lightly stroking the length of equine-meat pressed to his thigh. "I can't take you. I've never done anything like this before." He felt stupid saying it. "You know this already..."

"You don't have to," Nick breathed, rolling the two of them over so that he straddled Cody's hips, their shafts pressed together. "Take me. I'm here for you to experience as you will."

Cody's brow furrowed and he wrinkled his muzzle, wondering just how he was supposed to take the zebra when he was on the bottom. He knew the fundamentals of sex and that was not how it worked, surely? The 'mounting' partner was on top. He shook his head, clouded mind befuddled as a paw worked over his cock oh so tenderly.

"But how can I... Oh..."

How it would work quickly became apparent as the zebra shifted up on to his knees and pressed the tip of Cody's flesh-coloured cock to his tight pucker, ropey tail flipping out of the way. He rubbed it back and forth slowly, lips parted in a breathy moan. Cody briefly wondered how he had thought his room so cold before when he now had what could very well have been the hottest zebra in the world preparing ease down on his virgin cock. His heart thudded heavily, blood roaring in his ears as a wave of euphoria rocked him in dizziness, every sensation enhanced.

Luck *could* come.

"Don't we need...something?" Cody could not force his lips and tongue to form the words.

Sucking his fingers, the zebra shook his head fervently and pushed the digits into his tail with that little lubrication. Though his lips twisted in a slight look of discomfort, Nick drove them in deeper, curling them up against his prostrate with a nicker of pleasure. Cody watched avidly, eyes wide, and groaned as the zebra ground his cock along the buck's length, pre cum smearing slickly over both hard rods. Nick's eyes burned.

"I'll make do. For you, buck. You're worth it. So very worth it."

Moving forwards, he rested a paw on Cody's chest and grasped the buck's cock, raising it so the tip nuzzled into his tail hole. The buck gripped the zebra's hips in trembling paws and, as the buck rocked back, pushed up into his tight tail hole. He held his breath, not knowing what to expect, and moaned as his shaft was engulfed in hot tightness, the twitching, clenching rump near overpowering. Panting heavily, the zebra slid down, tail hole spreading wider to allow Cody's shaft inside. Though moderately sized – no one was about to whip out a ruler in the moment – it was more than enough to stretch the unprepared zebra and grind against his prostrate so deliciously.

"Are you okay?" Nick paused halfway down Cody's shaft, expression conflicted.

"Better...than okay..." The buck moaned and arched up, hooves planted on the bed for leverage. "Please, don't stop."

"You control what happens, buck," Nick dropped a kiss on his lips, rolling his hips luxuriously to ease down even further. "Take it as you will."

Swallowing, Cody nodded and thrust experimentally, spearing up into the zebra as he trembled, sweat matting the fur under his arms. The zebra grunted as he thrust, rocking in time with his clumsy motions as his tail flicked up, wildly swishing from fly to side, though he had no flies to swat away. Twisting, the buck dug his fingers into Nick's thighs and snorted, antlers knocking back against the headboard of the bed as he lost himself, instinct begging him to thrust hard, to breed and spill his seed. To the side of the bed, the carrier bags

of laundry lay spilled out over the carpet and the buck chuckled breathlessly at the ridiculousness of their presence. Why had he been so worried about doing laundry earlier? Then again, if he had not gone out in the snow for a laundry trip that was never to be, he would never have met Nick. And Christmas Eve as it was would never have happened.

Thank God for laundry.

Rolling his head against the pillows, the deer huffed and thrust wildly, getting into the motion and ramming in until his crotch was flush with the striped zebra rump, tail dangling between his legs. The buck shuddered and gasped for breath that would not come, cock pulsing and spurting what felt like far too much pre cum into the zebra's tight tail hole. With every thrust in, Nick groaned and rolled his hips, arching to allow the buck in as deep as possible. Supporting himself with one muscled arm, Nick grunted and trembled, nostrils flaring dramatically to show a flash of red inside as he heated up.

The pleasure was too much for a certain, inexperienced buck, however, and Cody gritted his teeth, eyes narrowed as pleasure rose and rose to an uncontainable high. In the dim light of the bedroom, he took in every nuance of the zebra's motion, striving to focus on that above all else to hold off for as long as he could. His body, conversely, was not to be denied and he clicked his teeth together as his hips jerked.

"I'm..." Cody gasped, ears pinned back. "Mmmph... Too close... Too soon!"

Words would not come in full sentences but even on the edge of orgasm, Cody wrapped his paw around Nick's forgotten shaft, finding it slippery with the zebra's pre cum. Grinding his cock up into the zebra, Cody did his best to pump the length in time with his thrusts, using the copious pre cum drooling down the thick length to smooth the path of his paw.

"Cum for me, buck," Nick whinnied, velvety lips curled back half from pleasure and half to taste the scents on the air, sex flooding his senses. "Fill me! Nice and deep, I want you, oh...I so want you."

His eyes were feverish and Cody grasped the paw that Nick was not using to support himself, winding his fingers between those belonging to the striped fur. The touch emboldened him and the buck panted as he anchored himself, hips thrusting up as his tail twitched, a white flash beneath a rump that the zebra had watched from a distance many encounters before. Though it was a much sweeter treat to give himself up to the buck than to take such a soul, a sensation that was inherently right in the warm of his chest.

Stroking swiftly, Cody squeezed behind the flare of Nick's cock, wishing he could give the tip a quick lick, just to taste what it was like, pre cum glistening on the tip. He wanted to drive the zebra over the edge at the same time that he lost control, but his own climax could be denied for no longer.

Turning his muzzle into the pillows to stifle his strangled yelp, Cody thrust like a fur gone mad, body beyond his control as he filled his partner's hole with cum, driving in as climax gripped him as if he was a snowflake in the blizzard rising outside. Nick arched as the buck ejaculated, grinding the cock buried in his rump against his prostrate, cock jumping in need. As the buck collapsed beneath him, paw working over his length, Nick tensed and neighed

loudly as he too reached his peak, . It was a good thing that the dorm was deserted, not that either of them would have cared.

Flopping back down on the bed, the buck groaned as his softening cock slipped from the zebra's rump with a barely audible pop. His ears twitched to catch the sound and he looked down through half-lidded eyes at his paw, which was covered in the zebra's cum. Blushing, he held Nick's gaze as he brought it experimentally to his lips and licked off the tiniest of tastes. His muzzle wrinkled and his ears shot up straight. As surprising as it was, the strong taste was not altogether unpleasant and Cody shyly lapped up more and more, chuffing as Nick drew in close to him to share the last drops. The zebra's tongue sensually caressed Cody's paw until not a drop of cum remained and their lips met in a kiss that tasted of masculine pleasure.

Cody's front was streaked with zebra cum, painting him with white stripes much like the culprit himself, but he could not bring himself to care. That would be a matter for the morning and was presently unimportant. He even kind of liked having the zebra's mark on him, as he had left his mark inside Nick's tail hole, cum trickling out of the hole that still needed to tighten up. Cody was a little proud of himself. The small amount of alcohol that he had consumed had left his head and warmth curled about his heart, something that he would only come to address a little later in time. Nick stroked his back, fingers pressing and massaging muscle as the buck sighed and relaxed into him, eyes closing even as he fought to stay awake. Nick would be leaving. He could not sleep.

The zebra tightened his arms around the buck.

"Sleep well, sweet buck. Nothing lasts forever, the bad as well as the good. Rest well and dream of the moment and the moment alone."

He kissed the top of Cody's head as the buck nuzzled into the pillows, one arm tight around Nick's waist.

"Life will come better. I promise."

*

Weak winter sunlight cast a rectangle of bright across the buck's muzzle and he rolled over in bed, grumbling as he strove to evade it. With an arm flung back over his head, he murmured in half-sleep, rubbed his muzzle and blinked blearily, fighting off the day. His stomach twisted and he knew on the edge of his waking mind that it was Christmas Day and he had to face the morning after the worst best dream he had had in a long time. It had involved a zebra with a smirk on his lips and a tale to tell, while his listening ear quivered intently...

Cody sighed, warm breath huffing over his pillow. His eyes moistened behind lowered lids and the buck wrapped his arms around his torso, squeezing tightly in memory of the dream embrace he had *felt* so vividly. It had been such a good dream. If only he could return to dreamland. Then everything would be all right again, better than all right.

Mumbling incoherently to himself, he sat up slowly and rubbed sleep from his eyes with the back of one paw. Stupid dreams. They always made him think that something better could happen but nothing special ever did happen, despite his best efforts. His lips turned down

sullenly as he stared across the room at a scrap of peeling wallpaper. The only good things in life happened to those who either stumbled blindly into them or had brilliance fall into their laps.

Cody sighed and scratched his antlers. No, he would not think like that. Maybe his luck would turn if he tried hard enough, faced another day like the zebra had told him to, just before he cupped his chin and kissed his lips so sweetly.

Nostrils flaring, the deer took in the strange scents of the room, unfamiliar in their potency as he regained a greater sense of the waking world. He dipped his muzzle to the bed sheets on the opposite side of the bed and licked his nose to better take in the scents, hardly daring to hope as his paw trembled. That was not his scent. Another prey animal had lain in his bed – scents could not lie!

On the second rickety bedside table sat a sprig of mistletoe and a simple, white envelope with a crisp edge with his name scrawled across the front.

Cody.

It had been no dream at all. Memories of the night before came rushing back one after the other and Cody blushed to think of his first time, catching sight of dried semen streaking the blue duvet, a mark of male pleasure. The buck chuckled under his breath and shook his head, reaching out to smooth the sheets flat. He never had gotten that laundry done.

But the zebra was not there. Nick was not there. Cody cast his eyes down. Had the zebra had enough of him? Had he been used? The tips of his ears tingled with heat, humiliation beating down on him as if he had become the skin of a drum. For a moment, Cody faltered, battling the voice inside that told him that no one wanted him, he would never amount to anything, it was all for nothing. The buck straightened his back, antlers held high.

No. He bolstered his resolve, that inner strength that Nick had spoken off. He was strong inside. Nick had said he was leaving. He knew this and the conclusion of his student programme was the one reason that he had left so early. Shyly, Cody ducked his muzzle down to his chest. The zebra had most likely not wanted to wake him. Or perhaps Nick was as bad at goodbyes as Cody felt he was.

Collecting the letter in one paw – for what else could the envelope contain? – Cody pressed it to his chest, not yet daring to open it. That would take greater courage after at least one coffee, but he was confident that it would be found. He only needed a little time to digest the enormity of what had happened, the loss of his virginity and crying on to Nick's shoulder. The buck's tail twitched and the beginnings of a grin pulled at his black lips, a smile for Christmas Day that could not be contained by the sorrows of days past.

He looked out the window to where a fresh layer of snow blanketed the ground, pure where he had last stomped across its pristine surface. The buck beamed at the day and sprung from bed, flinging the windows open and leaning out into the cold arms of the deserted campus. For the first time in more months than he could count, the buck felt *positive*, the letter clutched in his paw like a talisman. Even if Nick was gone, perhaps for a very long time, he knew one thing with irrevocable certainty.

The future was there for his taking. He brushed his lips over the envelope in a chaste kiss and broke the seal with the gleam of life in his eye.

Merry Christmas, Nick.